

**LISTENING  
#25****Teacher's Guide****SCRIPT: THE MONGOL EMPIRE**

**Presenter:** It was an amazing rise to power really for the Mongols from virtually nowhere, wasn't it? Because at the time, it is basically, what, feuding clans? How did they unite into this great force, and was that partly due to the leadership of Genghis Khan?

**Historian:** Well, I think we think of the Mongols as sort of appearing from nowhere, but actually it's not quite the case. In fact, across the spine of Asia, tribal groups would quite often form big umbrella groups and prove incredibly successful like the Huns, for example. Atilla, the greatest leader of the Huns in the third and fourth centuries.

So it's not unusual. There's normally a series of different triggers that allow for a big grouping to emerge like the Mongols do. And that's normally linked to some form of change in climate across the steppe lands, where the nomads keep their flocks. It's usually linked to a particularly charismatic and able military leader, as Genghis Khan clearly was. And then a series of sort of gateways that allow conquest to happen very quickly.

And I think when we when we think about the Mongols today, we think of savage, barbaric, ultra-violent warriors. But actually the Mongol world was one that was incredibly sophisticated, incredibly tolerant actually, particularly when it comes to things like religio. And the Mongols were extraordinarily good administrators.

The Mongols were very very good at integrating people within the tribal structures. They were very conscious of the fact that with lots of identities in play you could either suppress and force everyone to become like yourself, or you allow for as much oxygen to air in the system as possible.

And so the Mongols, they were spectacularly violent on occasion, but it was highly selective. It was intended to teach a very bloody moral. Cities like Nishapur and Merv in modern Turkmenistan were absolutely destroyed and leveled.

But those single acts, those cities that were that were savaged, opened up gateways because, by and large, people then didn't want to resist the Mongols as they spread across Asia And the Mongols that they did build an empire that was the biggest land empire that's ever been seen in history.

So we should probably think about what they did that was right and how that happened rather than to sort of think of the Mongols as sort of purely as barbarians who appeared from nowhere and went berserk.

## Answer Key

### Comprehension Activity

1. b) How the Mongols united and rose to power
2. She says it is not really accurate
3. b) The Huns
4. b) As a charismatic and skilled military leader
5. b) It was surprisingly sophisticated and tolerant
6. b) It was selective and meant to send a message
7. They were completely destroyed

### Reading Comprehension

1. Mainly for its conquests and military campaigns.
2. A postal network called the Yam.
3. They welcomed multiple faiths.

## Idioms

**“Open up gateways”** = create opportunities or remove obstacles

**“Popular imagination”** = the general public’s usual way of thinking about something

**“A balanced view”** = an opinion that considers different sides fairly